

MarkingForge

Studio deployment guide - for administrators

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.4.2

Installing MarkingForge on many workstations without dialogs, giving a whole team one dial layout and the standard shortcuts, updating and removing it - with the script `Studio\Deploy-MarkingForge.ps1` that comes in the download.

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What gets installed, and where

Part	Location	Who
The plugin (one folder)	%ProgramData%\Autodesk\ApplicationPlugins\MarkingForge	All users of the machine - needs administrator rights
	%APPDATA%\Autodesk\ApplicationPlugins\MarkingForge	One Windows user - no rights needed
Each user's dials and settings	%LOCALAPPDATA%\Autodesk\3dsMax\2027 - 64bit\ENU\en-US\plugcfg\MarkingForge	Per user, always. The English 3ds Max folder shown; other languages use their own ENU\xx-XX .

3ds Max loads the plugin from Application Plugins through its `PackageContents.xml` . Nothing is written into the 3ds Max program folder or the registry, and MarkingForge makes no network connections - no licence server, no telemetry.

Never install in both scopes. 3ds Max would load two copies and report a duplicate plugin at start-up. The script refuses to do it (exit code 4).

Licensing: one licence per person who uses MarkingForge (see LICENSE.txt). The deployment method does not change that.

Silent installation with the script

Run from the unzipped download, in an elevated PowerShell for all-users installs. 3ds Max must be closed.

```
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File "Studio\Deploy-MarkingForge.ps1" -Scope AllUsers
```

Parameters

Parameter	Type	What it does
<code>-Scope</code>	string	AllUsers or CurrentUser (default AllUsers).
<code>-Source</code>	string	The MarkingForge package folder (the one holding PackageContents.xml). Default: "Manual install\MarkingForge" of the download this script came in.
<code>-StudioMenus</code>	string	A studio dial layout for the CURRENT user: a menus.json or a preset saved with the editor's "Save preset...". An existing menus.json is backed up first.
<code>-SetupShortcuts</code>	switch	Give the current user the standard shortcuts (Alt / Ctrl+Alt / Shift+Alt + 1..8) on their next 3ds Max start - free keys only. Since 1.1.0 a first start does this by itself when no dial has a key yet; the switch also fills free slots of a user who already has some.
<code>-NoShortcuts</code>	switch	Leave the current user's keys alone on the next start - the first start would otherwise give the standard keys to a user without any.
<code>-Uninstall</code>	switch	Remove MarkingForge from this scope. Users' own settings are kept.
<code>-SettingsOnly</code>	switch	Only the per-user part (-StudioMenus / -SetupShortcuts): the plugin is neither installed nor checked. For log-on scripts on machines where the plugin was installed for all users.
<code>-KeepExistingMenus</code>	switch	With -StudioMenus: give the studio layout only to users who have NO menus.json yet - so a log-on script never overwrites what a user built.
<code>-AllowScripts</code>	switch	With -StudioMenus: accept a layout whose items run MAXScript (script or value items). Without it such a layout is refused, as the editor refuses a preset's scripts unless the user consents.
<code>-DryRun</code>	switch	Show what would be done; change nothing.
<code>-Force</code>	switch	Install even when a copy exists in the other scope (not recommended: 3ds Max would load the plugin twice).

Exit codes

Code	Meaning
0	Success.
2	No MarkingForge package at the source folder.
3	3ds Max is running - it holds the plugin file open. Close it and run again.
4	MarkingForge is installed in the other scope - 3ds Max would load it twice. Uninstall that copy first.
5	The update did not complete (a copy error or a file that does not match the package by SHA-256 - a disk, network or permission problem). The previous version is restored automatically; the output says so, or where its backup is.
6	The studio layout file is missing, not valid JSON or not a MarkingForge layout (schema 1). Checked before anything is installed, so nothing was changed.
7	The studio layout has items that run MAXScript (script or value items). Checked before anything is installed. Check them, then run again with -AllowScripts to install it anyway.

What the script does, in order

- 1 Stops if 3ds Max is running (it holds the plugin file open).
- 2 Checks the package: `PackageContents.xml` and `plugins\MarkingForge.gup` ; reads its version.
- 3 Stops if MarkingForge is installed in the other scope.
- 4 Backs up the installed version to `%TEMP%` (never next to the plugin, where 3ds Max would load it as a second copy).
- 5 Removes the previous version in this scope and copies the new one.
- 6 Verifies every file by SHA-256 against the package. If the copy or the check fails, the previous version is put back and the script ends with code 5 - a failed update never leaves a workstation without a working plugin.
- 7 Optionally prepares the current user's dial layout and first-start shortcuts.

Add `-DryRun` to any command to see these steps without changing anything.

Deployment tools

Any tool that can run a PowerShell script with administrator rights works - Microsoft Intune, Configuration Manager, PDQ Deploy, a Group Policy start-up script. Copy the download folder to a share and run:

```
powershell -NoProfile -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File
"\\server\apps\MarkingForge_1.4.2\Studio\Deploy-MarkingForge.ps1" -Scope AllUsers
```

Tool setting	Value
Install command	the line above
Uninstall command	the same with <code>-Uninstall</code>
Detection	file <code>%ProgramData%\Autodesk\ApplicationPlugins\MarkingForge\PackageContents.xml</code> containing <code>AppVersion="1.4.2"</code>
Success exit code	0
Requirement	3ds Max 2027 installed; 3ds Max not running (exit code 3 otherwise - retry later)

One dial layout for the whole team

- 1 On one workstation, build the layout in **MarkingForge > Menu editor...** and **Save**.
- 2 Copy that user's `menus.json` (or a file saved with **Save preset...**) to a share, for example `\\server\3d\MarkingForge\studio_menus.json`.
- 3 Give it to users from a **log-on script** (it runs as the user, so it reaches the user's own settings folder):

```
powershell -NoProfile -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File  
"\\server\apps\MarkingForge_1.4.2\Studio\Deploy-MarkingForge.ps1" ^  
-SettingsOnly -StudioMenus "\\server\3d\MarkingForge\studio_menus.json" -KeepExistingMenus -  
SetupShortcuts
```

Switch	Effect
<code>-SettingsOnly</code>	Only the user part - the plugin is not installed or touched.
<code>-StudioMenus</code>	Installs the layout as the user's <code>menus.json</code> ; an existing one is backed up first.
<code>-</code> <code>KeepExistingMenus</code>	Only for users who have no layout yet - a log-on script never overwrites what a user built.
<code>-AllowScripts</code>	Accept a studio layout with items that run MAXScript (script or value items). Without it such a layout is refused (exit code 7), as the editor refuses a preset's scripts unless you consent.
<code>-SetupShortcuts</code>	On the next start the user's free dials get Alt / Ctrl+Alt / Shift+Alt + 1-8. Keys the user already uses are skipped. Without it the first start does the same for a user who has no MarkingForge key at all.
<code>-NoShortcuts</code>	Leave the user's keys alone on the next start - for a studio that assigns its own keys.

To push a **new** studio layout to everybody, run once without `-KeepExistingMenus`. Each user's previous file stays next to it as `menus.json.bak_before_studio_<date>_<id>`.

Individual users can still change their dials in the editor; a preset loaded with **Load preset...** replaces only the dials it contains.

Updating and removing

Task	Command	Notes
Update	run the install command from the new version's folder	Users keep their dials and shortcuts.
Remove	<code>-Uninstall -Scope AllUsers</code>	User settings stay in each profile; delete <code>plugcfg\MarkingForge</code> to remove them too.
Move from per-user to all-users	<code>-Uninstall -Scope CurrentUser</code> (as that user), then install <code>-Scope AllUsers</code>	Avoids the double-load.

Verifying a workstation

In 3ds Max's MAXScript Listener (F11):

```
MarkingForge.version()      -- the installed version; "Unknown property" = not loaded
MarkingForge.configSummary() -- the user's menus.json, its dials and any errors
MF_TOOLS_DIR                -- where the editor is loaded from (the Application Plugins folder)
```

The start-up log `plugcfg\MarkingForge\menu_log.txt` records the menu being built and the first-start shortcuts.

Troubleshooting for administrators

Symptom	Cause and fix
Exit code 3	3ds Max is running on the workstation. Schedule for when it is closed, or retry.
Exit code 4	An older per-user installation exists. Remove it as that user (-Uninstall -Scope CurrentUser).
Duplicate plugin message at 3ds Max start	A copy of MarkingForge.gup in the 3ds Max plugins folder or in both scopes. Keep one.
Plugin not loaded	3ds Max 2027 missing or the Visual C++ 2015-2022 x64 runtime missing - install it.
Studio layout not applied	The user already had menus.json and -KeepExistingMenus was set, or 3ds Max runs in another language (settings folder ENU\xx-XX).
Shortcuts not set up	Keys already used by something else are skipped on purpose; the user can run MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...

Still stuck? Open an issue at github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues or write to forgeplugins@gmail.com.

MarkingForge > Report a bug... puts your 3ds Max and MarkingForge details on the clipboard, ready to paste.

Support, bug reports and feature requests

ISSUES	github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues
E-MAIL	forgeplugins@gmail.com
WEB	https://forgeplugins.tech (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)

Bug reports and feature requests are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

Reporting a bug

- 1 In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
- 2 Open github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues and pick **Bug report** - or answer **Yes** in the dialog to write an e-mail to forgeplugins@gmail.com instead.
- 3 Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
- 4 Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.